

Ministry of Misconduct

Can you stay corrupt?

TIMELINE	ROLE	CONTEXT	TOOLS
March 2026 – present (in progress)	Solo	Self-initiated outside class	p5.js

[Hero visual: animated GIF montage — decision moment → chain forming → chain breaking, ≤3 sec loop]

Draft — locked sections from audit: Hero, Context, Synthesis, Iteration. Research, Ideation, Current State, and What's next pending.

Context

Ministry of Misconduct is a game where you play the powerful person. The system is already broken. Your job is to keep it that way.

The project didn't start with a headline. It started with a shape — the same shape, showing up across different systems. A decision is made. Another decision builds on it. The pattern thickens. Nobody notices, until something breaks and people are briefly uncomfortable. Then the pattern resumes.

I made it a game because you can't argue with what you just did. You can read about corruption and disagree. You can watch a film about it and stay outside. But when you sit in the chair, make the choices, and watch your own chain hold — the discomfort lands somewhere reading and watching can't reach.

Synthesis

The game is built around a single inversion: the goal is to maintain corruption, not fight it. Everything in the design exists to make that inversion *felt* by the player — not described to them. Three principles came out of that commitment, and every later decision had to honor them.

Inversion must be felt, not understood.

A reader can disagree with an essay about corruption. A viewer can stay outside a film about it. But a player who has just maintained the chain — who pressed the button that kept the system intact — can't unfeel that. The discomfort isn't argued for; it's caused. This principle pushed me away from anything that explains the game's politics to the player. No narration, no on-screen morality, no "see, this is bad" framing. If the inversion has to be explained, it has already failed.

Pattern formation is the system.

Corruption is not one bad decision. It is the *shape* that decisions take when consistency is the goal. One honest choice doesn't reform a corrupt system — it exposes it, which is something different. This principle forced the central mechanic: a visible chain of choices, where every link has to align, and a single break is fatal. The game isn't asking the player to be evil. It's asking them to be *consistent*.

The player is the powerful one.

The player sits at the top of the pyramid. The choices in front of them are choices about people who never appear on screen — people whose lives sit at the bottom of the structure the player is holding up. Most games put the player in the role of resister, hero, or survivor. This one doesn't. The discomfort of the inversion lives partly here: in the experience of being the person whose small, abstract decisions reshape lives the player will never see.

These three principles are the test every version of the game had to pass. The next sections trace which versions passed, and which ones didn't.

Iteration

The game went through three versions before settling on its current form. The story isn't a smooth refinement — it's two distinct decisions to throw away a working prototype. The first because the concept was wrong. The second because the scope was.

V1 — Word shooter.

The first prototype borrowed the structure of a Space Invaders game. Words categorized into tension meters fell from the top of the screen. The player had to shoot or destroy them before they hit the ground. The intent was to make the political content reactive — let the player feel pressure as charged language piled up.

It didn't work. The form fought the idea. Shooting words is an arcade act, and arcade acts don't carry weight. The player wasn't sitting in a position of power; they were a reflex. None of the discomfort the project was reaching for had anywhere to land. The version was buildable, even fun in a thin way — and that was the problem. A fun word-shooter was further from the thesis than no game at all.

I cut it.

V2 — Papers Please structure.

The second prototype borrowed from *Papers Please* — a desk, files to sign or reject, three files a day, two to handle, relationship bars per stakeholder. This time the form was right. The desk put the player in the seat of power. The choices accumulated through stakeholders, which started to look like a pattern. The discomfort had a place to land.

But the scope was wrong. A desk-and-stakeholders game needs daily content, character writing, branching consequences, and visual variety to stay alive across multiple sessions. As a solo developer on a deadline, I couldn't sustain that scale without the project collapsing under its own weight. The version that captured the thesis was the version I couldn't finish.

That cut was harder than the first. V1 was wrong; killing it felt obvious. V2 was *right* and still had to go.

V3 — Chain mechanic.

The current version strips the form down to the smallest shape that still carries the thesis. Each turn, the player gets two choices. One sustains the chain. One breaks it. The chain is visible — it accumulates across the screen as the player makes decisions. Maintain it for the duration of the timer to win. Break it once and you're exposed.

Everything that wasn't load-bearing is gone. No stakeholders to manage, no daily calendar, no content treadmill. What remains is the smallest possible game that still asks the player to be consistent in service of something they shouldn't want to maintain. The form finally matches what the project has been about since the start.

V3 is what the rest of the case study covers — where it is now, and where it's going.

— end of locked draft —

Pending sections (not in this PDF): Research · Ideation · Current State · What's next